

SALES TRAINING DEBRIEF · SESSION 4

Rock Solid is the Energy. Say It, Then Deliver It.

Session led by Corie Dawson, Director

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The thesis in one line

Energy is not flamboyance. It is certainty. Certainty is built from one specific habit — saying something and then delivering exactly that, every time, until your word becomes the most trusted thing about you. This session puts a name on that certainty: rock solid. It is the difference between a deal closing and a deal walking.

“Rock solid comes from saying something and doing it — every single time, for the rest of your life. That’s how you become rich. People go: that person is dependable.” — Corie

1. What "rock solid" actually means

Across the team there is a habit of confusing energy with performance. High energy is not arm-waving, exclamation marks, or volume. High energy is visible certainty — the customer can feel that you know what you're saying is going to happen. They feel safe with you. That feeling, repeated across a pitch, is what closes a deal.

Rock-solid energy = the visible output of preparation

Rock solid isn't a personality trait — it's a track record. Take the example of how the team relates to our finance lead on numbers: nobody argues with them about numbers, because every time anyone has tested those numbers, they've held up. That trust didn't come from charisma. It came from never opening their mouth without having triple-checked the figure first.

“Rock solid is a feeling. It comes from time and time again testing the metal and walking away scratching your head saying: yeah, they were right again.” — Corie (paraphrased)

The diagnostic: are you rock solid right now?

Ask yourself, honestly:

- When you say a price to a prospect — does your voice carry certainty, or does it lift at the end like a question?
- When you commit to follow up on a date — do you call exactly at that time, or "around" that time?

- When you tell your manager you'll close X this week — is that a forecast, or a fact?
- When a client pushes back, do you hold the line or do you reach for a discount?

If any of those answers is soft, that's where the work is. Rock solid is built one specific promise at a time.

2. The 12-month contract objection

A common pattern: the prospect has been burned by a previous agency and wants to commit to only six months. The team's default response has been to bring the request back to the office and renegotiate.

Why "let me get back to you" is the wrong move

Every time you ferry a message back to the office, you signal to the prospect that you don't have authority. You break your rock-solid energy. You teach the prospect to negotiate against the boss instead of with you. And you create a habit on the office side of being asked to give discounts that should have been killed at the table.

The right play: the 6 + 12 structure

Bake the prospect's concern into a two-stage structure. The prospect signs a 6-month initial agreement. At the 6-month mark, if results have landed and both sides want to continue, they sign a fresh 12-month contract for the work going forward. Total commitment if they stay = 18 months (6 + 12). If results haven't landed at month six, they walk — no further obligation.

Everyone wins. The prospect feels protected: they're only committed to six months upfront, with a real exit if it doesn't work. We get something better than a single 12-month contract — we get a 6-month proving ground that, when it goes well, converts into a longer 12-month follow-on. The SEO work has the runway it needs to compound.

"I understand. We've had clients exactly like you who'd been burned by people who didn't know what they were doing — that's why we exist. Here's the deal: you sign 6 months upfront. If we haven't delivered by month six, you walk — no questions. If we have delivered, you sign a fresh 12-month contract at month six to keep going. That gives you full protection and us the runway to compound the results." — How to phrase it

Get the verbal commit BEFORE bringing the deal back

Before you say "let me check with my manager" — get a yes. Pin the prospect down: "If I can do a 6-month start that rolls into a 12-month contract at month six, are you telling me you'll sign the paperwork today?" If the answer isn't a clear yes, the offer is meaningless. Don't bring negotiations back to the office unless you have the verbal close.

3. The "I'm not signing today" diagnostic

A prospect telling you they need time is one of the most common moments in the call. Most reps fold here. The rock-solid play is a four-step diagnostic that ends in either a close or a clean walk-away.

The four-step sequence

1. **Match the energy.** "Perfect — I wouldn't expect you to sign today." That single sentence resets the dynamic. You're not begging. You're calm.
2. **Get a number.** "Just out of interest — out of 10, where are you sitting on what we've covered today?" A 10 means they're sold. A 9 means almost. A 7 means there's a real objection hiding.
3. **Surface the objection.** "7 — wow, I've really stuffed up. What's the main reason? I'm somewhat disappointed myself — what have I done wrong?" The slight self-blame opens the door. They'll tell you the real issue.
4. **Isolate the variable.** Whatever they name (almost always price), separate it from everything else and negotiate ONLY that. See Section 4.

"I need to do my due diligence" — translation

When a prospect says they need to research, think it over, talk to their accountant, talk to their lawyer, talk to their business coach — translate that immediately. It means one thing: price. Buyers are liars, not maliciously, but reflexively. The "due diligence" sentence is smoke. Walk through it.

"It's always the price. Always. They'll have you thinking otherwise, and that's the genius of the way the customer works." — Corie

4. Isolate the variable

Once you know it's price, separate price from everything else explicitly. Don't let the prospect bundle objections together (that's how they hide).

The script

"All things aside — let's just focus on price. If I can get you down to \$650, do you think that meets your budget, assuming the due diligence works out?"

If they say yes, you have a deal contingent only on price. If they say no, you have a different objection underneath — and you ask again until you find it.

Why isolation works

- It removes the prospect's ability to hide behind vague "I need to think about it."
- It anchors the negotiation on a single, solvable variable.
- It commits them to a yes on every other dimension — so when price is resolved, the deal closes automatically.

- It mirrors how a negotiation expert operates: never negotiate the bundle, always one lever at a time.

5. The hard close with a deadline

Once price is isolated and a target number is agreed, do not leave the timeline open. Set a date — and make YOU the one with the deadline, not them.

The script

"Look — let me speak to my manager. If we do the deal on Friday, \$650. If we can't do it on Friday, the price is off the table. Sound fair?"

This works on three levels:

- It transfers urgency from you to them. They now have a clock running.
- It positions you as having authorisation pending — which is rock solid, not desperate.
- It draws a clean line. If they don't answer on Friday, you walk — and they know it.

What to do if Friday comes and they're ghosting

Send one short message: "As discussed, Friday was the deadline. The \$650 price is closed. If you do want to come on board, please give me a call — but I can't honour that price anymore. Wish you well." Then you're done. Real prospects come back. Time-wasters never do. Either way you win — your rock-solid energy stays intact.

6. Burn the boats — Sun Tzu commitment

A long detour in the session on commitment. Corie's personal rule: when he wants to ensure he does something, he tells everyone publicly so he can't back out. Pilot's license? Bought the plane first. New business goal? Tells the team before the work is done.

"I burn my boats. I make a decision and I own it. If I intend to survive, it's cut my way through the enemy. The price of going back is higher than the price of going through." — Corie (paraphrased)

Translation for sales

Apply the same logic to commitments to prospects and to your own targets:

- Tell your manager your weekly target out loud. Burn the boat. Now you can't back-fill an excuse later.
- When you tell a prospect "I'll call you at 3:30 Friday" — that call goes at 3:30 Friday, not 3:31. Treat the time like a hard contract with yourself.
- When you set a follow-up date, treat your own diary as binding. The boat is burned. Show up.

7. The 10,000-hour reality

A reframing of where reps actually are in their career. The well-known "10,000 hours" rule for mastery applies to sales too. The session laid out the math.

The math

A national-level competitor in a serious hobby (sport, music, judo) typically clocks 12,000–15,000 hours over 20 years — about 2.5 hours a day, every day, for two decades. That includes both drilling (the boring repetition) and sparring (the live application).

Where the team actually sits

Most reps on the team are at 100–300 hours of actual sales work. That's ~1–2% of mastery. Worse, almost all of those hours are sparring — actual customer calls — with very little drilling time on scripts, objection handling, and price-isolation moves. You're doing the fun part without the foundational part.

"Sparring is 'let's see how it lands.' Drilling is 'let's build the move so it lands every time.' You've been sparring. You haven't been drilling. That's why every deal feels like a fresh fight." — Corie (paraphrased)

What to do about it

- Drill the four-step "I'm not signing today" diagnostic out loud, with a colleague, 10 times this week.
- Drill the "isolate the variable" script until you can say it in your sleep.
- Drill the hard-close-with-deadline language until the tone is matter-of-fact.
- Drilling feels boring. That's the point. The boring repetition is what produces rock solid.

8. Honesty, Integrity, Loyalty — connected to rock solid

The triad from Session 2 returns here, but tied specifically to rock-solid energy. Customers can feel where your loyalty actually sits. If half of you is on the client's side ("yeah Corie's being a dick about the price, between you and me...") the customer feels it and trusts you less, not more.

Loyalty leaks — rock solid breaks	Loyalty held — rock solid intact
You agree the brand price, then quietly tell the prospect you'll "see what you can do"	You hold the brand price and explain why it's worth it
You forward a discount request to the office without challenging it	You ask: "If I can get to \$X, are you signing today?" — pin the verbal commit first
You side with the prospect against the company in conversation	You side with the prospect against their problem, with the company's product
You leave promises soft ("I'll get back to you sometime this week")	You set exact times ("I'll call Friday at 3:30") and you call at 3:30

9. Be the safe option

When a prospect meets you for the first time, their default frame is "this is a salesperson, I should be careful." Talking yourself out of that frame doesn't work — saying "trust me" actually triggers the opposite. The only thing that breaks it is felt safety.

What "safe" looks like to a prospect

- You arrive when you said you would. Down to the minute.
- You know facts about their business they haven't mentioned (Session 2 research).
- You hold the price when they push.
- You're not desperate. You're willing to walk if it's not the right fit.
- You ask uncomfortable questions instead of dancing around them.

Cumulatively, those signals override the "salesperson" frame and replace it with "this person actually has their stuff together — I can probably trust them."

10. Language fixes for the week

Soft / leaking	Rock solid
"I'd love your business" (apologetic, qualifying)	"I want your business" (direct, rock solid)
"Where do we need to be roughly?"	"Where do I need to be on price?" (specific lever)
"Have a think about it" (open-ended)	"Out of 10, where are you sitting?" (forces a number)
"Let me check with my manager and get back to you"	"If I can do X, are you signing today?" (verbal commit first)
"It's a 12-month contract" (stated as a hurdle)	"You start with 6 months — then a fresh 12-month contract once we've proven it works" (framed as protection)

11. Behaviours to change this week

5. **Get the verbal commit before bringing anything back to the office.** "If I can do X — are you signing today?" If the answer isn't a clear yes, don't renegotiate.
6. **Run the four-step diagnostic on every "I need to think about it."** Match → number out of 10 → surface the real reason → isolate the variable.
7. **Translate "I need to do my due diligence" into "I have a price objection."** Every time. Don't fall for the smoke.
8. **Set hard deadlines you control.** "\$650 if we do the deal Friday. After Friday, the price is off the table." Then walk if Friday passes.
9. **Drill, don't just spar.** Pick one script (diagnostic, isolation, hard-close). Practise it out loud with a colleague 10 times this week. Drill the boring part.

10. **Replace "I'd love your business" with "I want your business."** Drop the apologetic qualifier. It signals weakness.
11. **Burn your own boats.** Announce your weekly target to the team. Make it impossible to quietly miss.
12. **Be the precise one.** When you say 3:30 — call at 3:30. When you say Friday — answer on Friday. Daily precision is what builds the rock-solid reputation.

Final reminder. There is no shortcut to rock solid. It is built one promise at a time. Every call you take this week is a chance to add a brick to the wall — or a chance to crack one out. Watch which one you're doing.